Commentary on the Praise of Confession

Deśanāstavavṛtti · Toh 1160 · Derge Tengyur
བཤགས་པའི་བསྟོད་པའི་འགྲེལ་པ།

The Commentary on the Praise of Confession, in Sanskrit Deśanāstavavṛtti and in Tibetan Bshags pa'i bstod pa'i 'grel pa, is an Indian commentary on a short hymn in which the poet confesses his misdeeds before the Buddha while praising him as the unequaled king of physicians, a hymn whose author the commentary identifies by the name Candra, traditionally Candragomin. Working through the hymn line by line, the commentator explains how praise of the Buddha's qualities becomes a means of confessing and purifying one's faults, and closes by dedicating the merit of the praise so that all beings may be born in Sukhāvatī, the Land of Bliss, and reach buddhahood. According to its colophon, it was composed by the master Buddhaśānti and translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Buddhaśrīśānti together with the great translator Rinchen Zangpo. It is Toh 1160 in the Tengyur, where it is placed in the section of praises (stotra) as a commentary on a hymn of praise.

In the language of India: deśana stava pṛtti
In the language of Tibet: Commentary on the Praise of Confession

Homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī.

Here, when praise is offered, those who compose praises speak with reference to three phases of the Buddha: that of the cause, that of the result, and that characterized by accomplishing what is needful. Praise, moreover, is offered in three ways: out of faith, out of great learning, or on falling into a situation of distress. Of these, the present praise arises chiefly from great learning; relying on the phase in which the Buddha accomplishes what is needful, it seeks to set forth the way of confessing misdeeds by proclaiming the qualities of the Blessed One. Therefore the author states the passage that begins:

King of physicians, unequaled, lord of beings,
Free of all faults, source from which good qualities spring:
Turning my mind to you, my refuge, I who am always sick
Shall describe the disorders of my own faults and confess them.

"King of physicians" means the chief of physicians, for he knows the science of healing sentient beings who are tormented by the disease of the afflictions and are bound for the lower destinies. For that very reason he is called

"unequaled": among Brahmā, Rudra (Śiva) and the rest, there is none equal to him in means. Moreover, because he teaches the supreme path to the beings of the three realms, he is "the lord of beings."

If one objects, "In that case śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are also lords of beings," the author says "free of all faults" to set him apart from them. Attachment, aversion, delusion and the rest are called faults because they obstruct the arising of genuine wisdom in the mindstream; he is free of them entirely, together with their habitual tendencies, and has abandoned them for good.

If one asks, "Is he the lord merely by being free of faults?", the author therefore says "source from which good qualities spring." Qualities are so called because they are to be trained in and refined; the term refers to the powers, the fearlessnesses and the rest. Their "source" is a synonym for the ground from which they are produced.

For these very reasons he is worthy to be a refuge, and so he is "refuge": relying on him one exhausts adverse factors such as misdeeds, and since he possesses the greatness of uncommon qualities, the Buddha, the Blessed One, is the supreme refuge; therefore he is called "refuge." "You" means that he has become the object apprehended by direct perception. "Turning my mind to" is to be construed thus: "Having fixed my mind on you with deep faith and made you directly present, I shall confess my faults."

If one asks why he confesses, the author says "always sick." This refers to a mindstream tormented by the disease of the afflictions and marked by grasping at self and what belongs to self; it does not refer to a disturbance of wind or the other humors, for that is not the subject here. "The disorders of my own faults" means: "Whatever the ways in which my own mind, under the power of the afflictions, has fallen from its nature and changed into another state, I shall express them in words and confess them, together with bodily gestures of respect such as joining my palms, and I shall declare them openly, without concealment."

Thus this first verse sets out the subject matter of the author's own undertaking, its connection, its purpose, and the purpose of that purpose. Confessing one's own faults by proclaiming the qualities of the Omniscient One is the subject matter, and the words of praise are its expression. Their relation as cause and effect is the connection. Turning away from the afflictions through knowing the path is the purpose. Relying on that, attaining by degrees

the very state of a buddha is the purpose of the purpose.

To show those very disorders of his faults, he states the passage that begins:

Like the current of a river very hard to cross,
With waves of wrong thought and analysis,
Churned up by the myriad seizing sea monsters of the afflictions,
Even my own mind knows no peace.

That is: "O Blessed One, in my own mind there is no peace, no freedom from the afflictions." If one asks how it has come to lack them, he says "like the current of a river very hard to cross." "Like" introduces an example: just as those who are swept along and tossed about by the violent current of a river undergo great suffering, so, in the abode of saṃsāra, tossed about by the current of the river of the afflictions, which is hard to turn back, my mind has neither peace nor happiness. That is the meaning.

If one asks why, he says "with waves of wrong thought and analysis." Thought is so called because it conceives: it is the coarse movement of the mind. Analysis is so called because it examines: it is the subtle aspect of the mind. Being thought and analysis and also wrong, they are "wrong thought and analysis," that is, afflicted. These are the waves; the mind is "with waves" because it is in a state of being churned and tossed by afflicted thought and analysis, and for that very reason it is hard to cross.

If one asks what else it is like, he says "churned up by the myriad seizing sea monsters of the afflictions." Under the power of wrong thought and analysis, afflictions such as attachment are produced; since these produce suffering and seize in a tight grip, they share the nature of sea monsters, the creatures of the ocean, and so are called sea monsters. "Myriad" refers to their great multitude. "Churned up" by them means pervaded and thrown into turmoil. For this reason, as long as afflicted thought has not been cleared away, one's own mind does not become calm, nor a ground for the arising of wholesome qualities. As the Salt River Sūtra says:

I have no fear of thieves who steal wealth;
Were they to steal fine riches, those I do not have.
But the wealth of virtue in my mind, so well and so diligently amassed,
My ordinary thoughts plunder before my very eyes.
In mountain retreats, in dark chambers and in dense forests,
Wealth can be well guarded from thieves;
But a place where the wealth of virtue is not ravaged

By these ignoble thoughts, go where one may, does not exist.

In this regard, at the very first, the Blessed One taught impurity, loving-kindness, and dependent origination, respectively, to those possessed of attachment, aversion, and delusion, and he spoke of the four abodes of Brahmā (brahmavihāras). To show that he himself has come into a state at odds with this teaching, the author speaks the passage that begins:

When the great waves of the ocean of attachment churn,
If I rely on the boat of impurity,
Then my mind, by the fire of aversion,
Is surely burned like dry grass, utterly destroyed.

Attachment is attachment to sense pleasures and attachment to things. Because it is so abundant and so powerful, it is an ocean. The waves are the many conceptual thoughts that accompany it, by which it is churned, shaken, and tossed about. As that same sūtra explains:

Just as the ocean into which clear waters flow,
Though still, is churned up by the waves,
So the water of the mind that has become one-pointed
Is churned up by conceptual thought.

If one asks, "When things have come to this, what is to be done?", one must rely on an antidote, and so he says, "If I rely on the boat of impurity." That is, if, in order to dispel it, one meditates on impurity, that is, on unattractive things, and so comes to rely on and abide in the boat that is the means of crossing the ocean of attachment.

If one asks how the mind fares in that situation, he says:

Then my mind, by the fire of aversion,
Is surely burned like something dry, utterly destroyed.

"In that phase of meditation, because I relied on objects unpleasing to the mind, my mind was harmed by the fire of aversion, like something dry being burned, but I did not find a peaceful mind free of attachment." In this way he declares his own fault.

Someone may say, "When one has been harmed by aversion in this way, surely one should rely on its own antidote." To this he speaks the passage that begins, "In order to quell the torment of aversion's fire." Aversion is the intention to harm others; it takes the form of malice. That itself is the fire, for

the torment of mental unhappiness that arises from it burns the mental continuum through and through. To quell is to calm that harm, that is, to turn the stream of the mind back from it. "In order to" means for that purpose.

If one asks what one does in order to quell it, he says, "Though I cultivate the pool of loving-kindness." That is, even though, as the antidote to the fire of aversion, one has cultivated and extensively practiced loving-kindness, which wishes all sentient beings to be happy, a mind of affection that, cool like the water of a pool, is able to quench the fire of aversion.

If one asks what comes of that, he says, "There, wishing happiness for all people." That is, in that phase of meditating in this way, there is a mind that focuses with loving-kindness on "all people," meaning all beings without exception who belong to the three realms, wishing them happiness and delighting in their freedom from harm.

If one asks, "When the mind is directed in this way, what happens?", he says, "The mind is seized by the mire of attachment." When one wishes beings happiness with a mind of loving-kindness, there arises the attachment of craving, bound up with a mind of rejoicing; and since this becomes a place where the mind clings and sinks, it is a mire. By such a thing the mind is wholly seized. This is what it shows: because a mind of loving-kindness accompanied by delight gives rise to an attached grasping toward beings, that itself is a fault.

If one asks, "In that case, how is one to practice?", he says, "To wholly purify the stain of the mire of attachment." Attachment is clinging to things. Because it is a cause of saṃsāra, it is like mire. That very thing is the stain: the defect of clinging to self and to what belongs to self, which has settled upon one's own mind.

If one asks what is to be done to purify and cleanse such a stain, he says, "Though I wash it with the water of equanimity." That attachment, which is like the stain of mire, is to be recognized as a fault through the understanding of wisdom. And if one asks what fault arises when one washes it with equanimity, which is like water, without any regard for any being and free of fondness and hostility, and so removes the stain, he says:

There, even the compassion that dispels the misery of all beings,
O Protector of the World, falls into ruin.

O Protector of the World, in that situation of resting in equanimity in this way, even great compassion, which, being fully engaged in delivering all sentient beings, dispels the suffering of all beings, and which has become the protector and refuge of the world, falls into ruin and is gone. Therefore I do not become a bodhisattva.

Someone may say, "Then surely one should contemplate that very compassion as well." He says:

Lord, if I meditate on compassion,
Great sorrow arises in me through and through.

"Lord" is a term of address. If, having seen that fault, I meditate on compassion itself and make it manifest, then in my mind there arises, through and through, the great anguish of mind called sorrow, which comes by way of compassion. The meaning is that a mind of sorrow, thinking, "Alas! These sentient beings are thoroughly afflicted by suffering!", becomes intensely anguished.

If one asks what is to be done about that, he says, "If, to quell this, I resort to joy." That is, if, so that the anguish born of compassion may be quelled and the mind may rest in evenness, one relies on and abides in the abode of Brahmā called joy. If one asks what comes of that, he says, "The wavering mind turns into sheer excitement." When the mind is set in this way upon joyful things, the mind, which wavers toward its objects and keeps changing, becomes excited and puffed up through elation, and does not remain at peace in its intrinsic nature.

Someone may say, "But surely, in order to calm that very excitement, one should rely on some other means." To this he says:

If, to quell joy, I cultivate disenchantment,
There the mind helplessly becomes dejected.

When, in order to calm a mind elated by joy, one focuses on things that produce disenchantment, such as the aspect of suffering, and so cultivates disenchantment, then in that situation, because of that very disenchantment, the mind loses its self-mastery and becomes dejected; it cannot direct itself to its object, and its effort grows feeble. That is the meaning.

If one asks, "When it has come to this, what fault arises if one lifts it up with enthusiasm?", he speaks the passage that begins:

If by effort I raise it up from its lowness,
It becomes the domain of the enemy, pride.

Even if, being endowed with diligence and effort, one lifts the mind up from its dejection and lowness by any means whatever that produces elation, that too becomes a fault. What fault? One falls under the power of pride. The mind becomes the domain of pride, excessive pride, and the rest, which like enemies destroy the wealth of virtue, and it falls under their sway. The meaning is that one becomes the slave of that enemy called pride.

Having thus shown the faults that arise in the mind when one focuses on the four abodes of Brahmā, he now shows how relying on the antidote to pride also becomes a fault, and so he says, "As its antidote I meditate on the emptiness of all things." In order to dispel that enemy called pride, there is what serves as its antidote, called "the emptiness of all things," which dispels all the workings of the mind. Through meditating on this emptiness, which dissolves all things, moving and unmoving, all the adverse factors such as pride are turned back. This turning back resembles either things whose defining characteristic is mutual exclusion, such as darkness and light, or things whose defining characteristic is that they cannot abide together, such as material substances and objects like a pot and a cloth. Here, however, the non-coexistence of material things is set aside; it is to be understood in terms of meditation on the meaning of emptiness.

If one asks, "And when one meditates on the meaning of emptiness in this way, what happens?", he says, "There I lose my diligence for the welfare of others." In that situation of meditating on all things as empty, since neither oneself nor sentient beings are apprehended, there is no diligence or effort to bring other beings to maturity and to work for the welfare of beings. The meaning is that one turns away from that.

If one asks, "Since such a fault has arisen, what should one focus on?", for this reason he says, "If to that end I rely on the conventional." That is, when, in order to remove that fault of viewing things as emptiness, one relies on and abides in what is called the conventional (saṃvṛti), which veils the seeing of the true meaning, namely the phenomena of things.

If one asks what fault arises from that as well, he says, "There the mind gives rise to thoughts of wealth." When the mind is applied to things in this way, there arise thoughts of somehow increasing and acquiring wealth through trade and the like, and so the mind becomes anguished and afflicted. For

when, relying on the conventional, one wishes to give things away in generosity and so forth, the thought arises of amassing many kinds of wealth, such as gold and jewels.

If one asks, "Even if one does give rise to thoughts of amassing wealth in this way, what fault is there?", he says, "If I set my mind on amassing wealth." That is, if, having developed craving for wealth and abandoned the special practices such as meditative concentration, one applies one's own mind to amassing and gathering wealth such as gold and generates craving, then at that time the mind has indeed fallen under the sway of distortion. And so:

It plies me with the liquor of every fault.

This means that when one is despised by others, one grows heedless, and faults such as bodily affliction arise; and through these very faults, the person who would protect himself with wealth is plied with that liquor, as it were, which becomes the cause of faults, and so they arise in him.

If one asks what further fault there will be, he says, "Drunk with the sleep of arrogance and delusion." By those very causes the mind is made drunk, not knowing the difference between what should be done and what should not be done. If one asks by what it is made drunk, it is "by the sleep of arrogance and delusion." Like a drunken man, one is arrogant and puffed up, one's intelligence is impaired by delusion, and one falls under the power of sleep and torpor. Through arrogance one is deluded, and through delusion one becomes drunk with sleep.

If one asks what fault arises from these as well, he says, "All that I aspire to is indeed destroyed." All the aims one aspires to are destroyed and lost: whatever the holy should accomplish in this life and in other births, or whatever serves as the cause of high rebirth and of the definitive good. The word "indeed" is for emphasis.

The summarized meaning here is this: amassing wealth is craving, and that is the cause of faults such as being held in utter contempt. As the Salt River Sūtra says:

It is this that destroys all respect
And all good qualities;
By it even one as weighty as Mount Meru
Is made as light as cotton.
Through craving, in the season of winter,

Even the cold of the Himālayas,
And in the deserts the blazing rays of the sun,
Are not felt at all.
Through craving, the ocean, whose depths are boundless
And which is fearsome with many perils,
Is thought to be no more than an ox's hoofprint,
Exceedingly small.

Having thus shown how the mind is unbalanced, he now shows that the mind is out of accord even with generosity, which is how the essence is to be drawn from amassed wealth, and so he speaks the passage that begins:

Even when I wish to give,
Mighty avarice holds me firmly in its grip.

That is, even at the times when I wish to give the wealth I amassed with difficulty to those who ask, and am eager to distribute it, "mighty avarice," the bonds of avarice that cling and are attached to things, which date from beginningless time and are powerful, take a firm hold and cling tightly to my mind, and so leave me without the power to give.

If one asks what is to be done at that time, he speaks the passage that begins:

Even if I dispel it and do manage to give,
Then for a long time after I regret it.

Even if, through the power of cultivating its antidote, one dispels and abandons that avarice and gives some things to some who are fields of merit, then, once again, through the anguish of mind that comes from the craving of avarice, one comes to regret for a long time the goods one gave away.

If one asks, "And if, through steadfast conviction, one turns that mind back again, what happens then?", he says, "Even if through faith I make it clear once more." Faith is clarity of mind. Even if, through faith, which is trust and aspiration toward good qualities, one removes the stains of the mind and makes it clear and free of turbidity, "It falls to the fruits of the world beyond." This means that the mind becomes tainted, clinging even to the fruit of the goods given away and hoping for a return.

When it has become tainted in this way, he says, "If, knowing impermanence, I give up hope." That is, recalling the word of the Teacher, who said, "All formations are impermanent," and examining the many aspects of

impermanence, by that antidote, the understanding that goods and the like have no permanence but are momentary in nature, one makes oneself unattached to the hope of a return, or to the wealth and so forth that come from the karmic maturation of generosity, and so removes that turbidity of the mind. If one asks what happens even when one abides in accord with this, he says, "With no motive left, it is cast down by laziness." The sense is this: it is because through this cause, the giving of gifts, one obtains such great wealth, that one strives at the causes, such as generosity, in order to achieve such a result. But because one has made oneself free of hope for the result, one no longer wishes to exert oneself in such practices as generosity, and through the power of laziness the mind becomes dejected and faint-hearted.

Having shown his confession by declaring how he has failed in his own welfare, he now shows that he has also failed in the welfare of others, and so he says, "O Protector, the world is sorely tormented by suffering." O Protector, these worlds of sentient beings are sorely tormented and made utterly wretched by the sufferings known as three, beginning with that of formations, or as eight, beginning with birth. And as for them, "Seeing that in former lives too they were my kin" means: having seen with my understanding and reflected in my mind that in other lives as well, through the succession of births in this abode of saṃsāra, they became my kin, such as father and mother, and were bound up with me. The word "too" means not only in the present.

If one asks what one does on that basis, he says, "Even when I wish to work for the welfare of others." Since there are no sentient beings oppressed by suffering who have not been my kin, I resolve, "In order to remove their harm, I shall work for the welfare of others through generosity and the like," and I wish to practice the conduct of a bodhisattva. If one asks what becomes of this even when one sets about accomplishing that task fully, he says, "The perception of a self seizes me helplessly." Out of clinging to relatives and the like, the perception of "I" and "mine," which arises from habitual tendencies, seizes me so that I have no self-mastery and brings me under its power, and so I fall into the distortion of viewing as a self what has no self. That is the meaning.

If one asks what fault there is in viewing things as a self in this way, he says, "Pride follows upon the view of self." The thought "There is such a thing as a self" is the view of self. Whatever conceit presumes what has no self to be a self, that is pride, and that pride follows upon the view of self. The meaning is that one comes to cling to the views of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), such as

permanence, stability, and the existence of a self.

If one asks what fault this in turn produces, he says, "It grasps at things as 'mine.'" That downfall which arises from pride gives rise to a tight grasping that thinks "mine," or "my own," and by this one is bound.

If one asks what host of faults this state of affairs then produces, he says, "There, by pride, arrogance, desire, and the rest." "There" means at that time, in the situation in which the grasping at "mine" arises: faults such as pride occur. Pride is the faults of pride, excessive pride, and the like. Arrogance is the mind swelling up and holding itself high. Desire is wanting, by which craving arises for objects of attachment. The words "and the rest" include the other afflictions, such as aversion and delusion. If one asks what these in turn do, he says, "Like an enraged enemy, they wreak utter destruction." Just as hostile enemies, when they are enraged, inflict many harms, such as depriving one of life, in the same way these hosts of afflictions rob one of the life of virtue and produce the various sufferings of change. For the view of self is the ground of all faults. As the master Dharmakīrti explains:

When there is a self, there is the perception of other;
From the division into self and other come clinging and aversion;
And from being wholly bound up with these two,
All faults come to arise.

To illustrate how those very faults, such as pride, give rise to what is adverse, he speaks the passage that begins:

When the net of afflictions, terrifying like the army of Māra,
Has swelled on every side,

"When" means at whatever time. "The army of Māra": Māra is the lord of the desire realm, and his army is his host of troops. Bearing all kinds of weapons and displaying many ways of attacking and entering battle, they are utterly terrifying. "Like" means similar, for the hosts of afflictions too are terrifying, since they produce all kinds of harm.

"Afflictions" are attachment and the rest. "Net" refers to their great multitude, or else to the way they entangle one on every side, tying one up and binding one. When such afflictions have swelled on every side, when the latent tendencies toward objects have been awakened and the entanglements of affliction blaze up in every way, then the host of afflictions is itself the army of Māra.

When the force of such dreadful afflictions has blazed up, then, as he says, "Then, like the dreadful Night of Kāla." Kāla (Time) is a messenger of Yama, the lord of death. The night on which he means to bind a noose around a person's neck and carry him off is called the Night of Kāla. "Like" means similar: the net of afflictions resembles it in character, for the two share the property of producing utterly dreadful terror.

Being like that, "The darkness of the dark side spreads": the darkness of delusion, which is Māra's side and is opposed to the white, virtuous qualities, spreads and grows. Or else, "the dark side" refers to the waning half of the month. Just as it is utterly terrifying if, in its pitch darkness, some enemies rain down weapons of every kind, so too, when one is obscured by the darkness of the afflictions' side and deprived of the light of the white, virtuous qualities, all kinds of harm and suffering spread and grow. That is the meaning.

Thus, by setting forth many similes, he has shown that the hosts of afflictions that arise from the view of self are utterly terrifying. For that very reason, wishing to confess by censuring his misdeeds in order to quell them, he says:

I shall declare my misdeeds, whose remorse is hard to bear;
Birth is suffering, and its change unbearable.
What harm could there be greater than this?
Even so, I myself engage in them.

O Blessed One, in your presence I shall declare and proclaim whatever misdeeds I have committed and accumulated, the many misdeeds done on account of the pleasant and the unpleasant. If one asks what they are like, they are those "whose remorse is hard to bear." For it is the nature of a misdeed that, once it has been done, there arises a remorse that can burn the mental continuum, hard to bear and hard to endure.

If one asks what else they are like, he says, "Birth is suffering, and its change unbearable." Birth is taking on a body in the five destinies. Suffering is what has the nature of the five aggregates. "Birth is suffering": birth is suffering, and when one takes it up and grasps it again and again, it produces the suffering of change, born of karma and afflictions, and makes one experience it; and that is unbearable. The meaning is that it stirs up many sufferings of body and mind that are extremely hard to bear.

This being so, "What harm could there be greater than this?" By way of the question, "What thing could there be that does harm greater than the suffering that arises from the afflictions?", it affirms emphatically that there is no harm

whatever greater than this.

Having understood in this way that they are the cause of unbearable suffering, it would be right to cast them off, yet one does not do so: "Even so, I myself engage in them." Though they are indeed the cause of suffering, I myself directly engage in the misdeeds that are its cause and do not turn back from them; this is because I have fallen under the power of the afflictions. So he confesses by declaring his own fault.

If that is so, it would be right to turn the mind back from them and abandon them; but to show that even then he is unable to be patient, he says:

If from the cause of manifold suffering,
From doing harm to others, I turn back,
Wicked people, become my enemies though I did no wrong,
Stir it up with a cruelty like the edge of a sword.

For patience is the source of all happiness, while anger is the ground of all suffering. Therefore, "If from the cause of manifold suffering": what has become the ground and cause of the manifold sufferings of this world and the next, arising in body and mind, is aversion, for from it comes the harming of sentient beings. "From doing harm to others, I turn back": that is, when, recalling the faults of anger, one turns the mind back from harming others and making them suffer through causes born of anger, and, recalling the antidote, relies on patience.

If one asks what happens when one abides in this way, he says, "Wicked people, become my enemies though I did no wrong, stir it up with a cruelty like the edge of a sword." One cannot bear it: the understanding is stirred up and the stream of the mind is made turbid. If one asks by whom, it is "wicked people, become my enemies though I did no wrong," who "stir it up with a cruelty like the edge of a sword." That is, people of wicked nature, lacking the conduct of the holy, such as moral discipline and patience, have become enemies without cause, with no ground in any wrong of my having harmed them, and remain hostile; and their conduct, cruel and wounding to the heart like the edge of a sword, stirs up my mind.

Someone may say, "But surely one should practice patience even toward those of wicked nature, and be kind to them." He says:

Even when my mind wishes to be patient,
Then their misconduct binds it tight in fetters.

At whatever time or moment I wish to turn my mind back from what stirs it up, to make it clear through the antidote, and to abide in the way of patience, even then the many kinds of behavior of that enemy of wicked nature, wicked by nature and doing all sorts of harm, which have become fetters of the mind, bind the mind once again and fetter it tightly, and so I fall under the power of aversion. That is the meaning.

Someone may say, "Even so, surely one should regard their behavior with equanimity and hold the mind in check." He speaks the passage that begins:

When it is checked and wholly held in restraint,
By the fire of fierce aversion it is parched through, bereft of tenderness.

When the bond of aversion that arises from their wicked behavior is forcibly checked and wholly restrained, then, precisely because it has been held down too hard, the stream of the mind does not stay in its natural state but falls under the power of anger. Therefore the fierce aversion that arises from this is like a fire, since it torments oneself and others. That fire parches the mental continuum, since it parts the mind from the moisture of the noble Dharma. Being so, the mind is bereft of tenderness and without compassion; it has lost the conduct of the holy, which is patient and serene. That is the meaning.

If one asks how a mind thus bereft of tenderness fares, he speaks the passage that begins, "Just as the dreadful ones whose glance is venom." "Just as" introduces an example. "The dreadful ones whose glance is venom" are serpents which cannot kill by a mere glance, but are able to make one faint with their venomous breath. "The tree in which they dwell the wise avoid" means that a tree in whose hollow such a vicious serpent has made its home, the wise, those endowed with intelligence, avoid from far off, and at once.

So too my heart, which hides within it the conduct of anger,
Is shunned by all that is virtuous.

This sets out the point of the example. In just that way, "anger" is the conduct that arises from the side of aversion, which is like a vicious serpent, and that harms others like venom; "my heart," which hides and conceals it as something dwelling within, is the aspect of mind that is like the tree. That heart is shunned and cast off by "all that is virtuous," that is, by the collections of actions that serve as causes of high rebirth and of the definitive good, such as the three trainings. This is what it shows: if the serpent-like conduct of aversion, accompanied by malice, dwells in my mind, that mind is like a poisoned vessel, and so virtuous qualities do not remain in it but shun it. That

is the meaning.

To show still further how the mind, being tainted, does not become a vessel for the Dharma, he speaks the passage that begins, "By the rays of the sun." This is to be construed with the words, "On my heart the falling of the rain of the holy Dharma is of no avail." If one asks in what way, he says, "Like a stone scorched by the rays of the sun." It is like rain falling on a slab of stone scorched and baked by the intensely hot, piercing rays of the summer sun. "Like" indicates a shared property. Just as, though streams of rain fall upon the face of a stone, no growth or sprouting of shoots or the like appears, nor does it become soaked within, but only its outer surface becomes damp, and even that vanishes in a moment, so too, on a mind tormented by hundreds of hosts of afflictions as fierce as the rays of the sun, the rain of Dharma is of no avail.

If one asks what else it is like, he says, "Like ashes that, utterly parched, have turned to dust." It is like ashes: a heap of ashes thoroughly baked and completely dried by the rays of the sun turns to dust and becomes very rough. Just as, though rain may fall on a heap of ashes that has become dry and rough, nothing worthwhile grows from it, and so it is of no avail; and even if, by falling abundantly, it makes the ashes somewhat damp, at another time they remain just as before; in the same way, on my mind, bound by hosts of wicked conceptual thoughts dating from beginningless time and become like dust, the falling of the rain of Dharma is of no avail.

If one asks what else it is like, he says, "Like a road covered over with heaps of sand." "Heaps of sand" means piles of sand, that is, a great deal of it. "Covered over" by it means wholly covered and blanketed. On a road through such a region, the falling of rain is of no avail. "Like" introduces an example: just as, though streams of rain fall abundantly on a road covered with heaps of sand, they serve no purpose, and before long it remains just as it was before, in the same way, "On my heart the rain of Dharma is of no avail": on the ground of my mind, covered over by ignorance, craving, and the rest, which are like sand, the falling of the rain of the true Dharma is of no avail.

Through these examples it shows this: just as rain falling on good farmland is worthwhile for those who look to the harvest, since it makes the crops of grain and fruit grow and flourish, it is not so on the back of a stone, on a heap of ashes, or on a sandy road. This is taught by examples of contrast. Three examples are given because there are three kinds of Dharma, namely scripture, realization, and the ultimate, and they are to be matched in order

with the futility of relying on these; or else they are to be matched in order with not having become a vessel for the teaching of the Dharma of the three vehicles.

The master's intention here is this. Even for those adorned with a great host of good qualities and endowed with the conduct of the holy, reproaching oneself is, for the time being, part of what one should do. If, without careful examination, or under the influence of non-virtuous friends, one has committed non-virtuous misdeeds, the means of purifying them is self-reproach; or else, by showing others in this way, it brings them to set right their faults. For through the power of repudiation one becomes free of misdeeds, as it is said:

Even a most dreadful misdeed one has done
Is cleared away by thoroughly reproaching oneself.

This approach is to be applied both in this context and in others as well.

To show still other ways of reproaching oneself, he speaks the passage that begins, "My own suffering." Its meaning is as follows. "O Protector of the World" addresses the Blessed One. Moreover, I am unable to bear it: not only do I lack respect for the path you have taught, so that it is of no use to me, but I have not been able even to know you and rely on you. That is the sense of the word "even."

Why is that? He says, "Because I have not examined my own unbearable suffering." The mass of suffering that I myself experience, fierce and harsh, unbearable and hard to endure, has arisen from the ripening of misdeeds, and I have not examined this with my intellect or reflected upon it: that is the reason.

"You who are like one striving to benefit me" means one such as you, who has become like a dear friend who strives to benefit me and turns me back from harm. Or else, without taking "like" as a simile, one may also take it as restrictive, "you who are the very one striving to benefit me," meaning you who have become the very one who strives to benefit me.

By what means? He says:

"You who benefit me through patience and generosity,
O Protector of the World, even you I am unable to bear."

Patience here is the perfection of patience, and generosity is the perfection of generosity. These two are named as the chief ones because they are the most

excellent of the means for benefiting others. You are of a disposition that supremely benefits others and accomplishes what they need through these two, and when you teach them, I am unable to bear them and rely on them. That is the meaning.

If one asks what I do in being unable to bear it, he says, "Whether I hate you, or flee and run away." To hate is to perceive as an enemy. What else do I do? I flee and run away: when beneficial instructions are taught, I cannot bear them and go elsewhere.

"Or am utterly distracted, or rebuff you, even then": being distracted means not taking up the instructions, roaming here and there, and turning the mind toward one place or another. "Or rebuff you" means that even while staying right where I am, I answer back with words, rebuffing and reviling. The word "even" shows how extremely difficult this is: for even to one like that, hard to tame, unruly, and without good fortune because his mental continuum is perversely inclined, you teach, and you bestow the rain of the sublime Dharma. So even to those like me, without good fortune and wicked by nature:

"You teach those like me without interruption,
Yet I do not think, 'One like this is my guru.'"

This means that you teach without interruption, lead them into knowledge, and make them fortunate. "One like this" means: I do not think, "This is the guru who teaches beneficial instructions even to one like that." The sense is that because the eye of my intellect is blinded by ignorance, I misapprehend. What this teaches is that just as those born blind do not know the appearance of the sun and moon, so too sentient beings who have not cultivated the continuum of their body and mind are unable to realize the meaning of the profound Dharma or to take up beneficial instructions.

Having thus spoken of the various ways the mind is altered by its faults, now, to show how one also makes requests of the Blessed One with a sound mind, he speaks the passage beginning, "Even when one goes and makes requests, it is hard to find." "Goes" means that when there is some source of benefit, one who seeks it goes into its presence, wins its favor with service and the like, and makes requests; and even so, it is, as it were, hard to find and hard to obtain. And the lines

"The supreme great medicine at the time for patience,
If I cannot bear the disposition of patience,"

mean this: when the mind, harassed by the enemy that is anger, has been wounded, it must be healed by such means as willingly accepting suffering. Therefore the medicine to rely on at that time, great because it heals the sickness of the mind and supreme because it far surpasses other means, is patience. Since patience must be relied upon, "the disposition of patience" means its very nature. If I do not bear it and rely on it, then "What other cause of patience do I have" to heal the sickness of aversion? That is, what other means that is a cause of patience do I have? I have none. That is the meaning.

Now, to show how, through the afflictions, one is left with no control of one's own, he says:

"Seized by the rākṣasas (flesh-eating demons) of the afflictions, their minds disturbed,
Fevered, making no effort even for their own good:
When I see the world, so deserving to be looked upon,
O Lord, only aversion arises in me, not compassion."

Calling out "O Lord," he shows: "In my mind aversion arises; compassion has never arisen." Toward whom does compassion not arise? Toward the world. What is it like? He says, "Seized by the rākṣasas of the afflictions, their minds disturbed." The afflictions, such as attachment and aversion, are like rākṣasas because they bring about terror and harm. Seized and overpowered by them, the mental continuum is disturbed and robbed of its independence. For that very reason they are "fevered": their minds are faulty and intoxicated by adverse factors. Because of this, they make no effort even to engage in undertaking the means of benefiting themselves, the actions that would free them from suffering in this world or the next, but cast these aside altogether; or else, disturbed by the afflictions, they harm themselves by leaping from a precipice or by taking poison. Such worldly people are said to be "deserving to be looked upon." Those at the sight of whom a mind of loving tenderness arises, and who become objects of compassion, are a cause of coming into accord with the conduct of bodhisattvas, and therefore it is fitting to look upon them. Yet even when I see such beings, because the afflictions are so powerful, aversion alone arises, not compassion.

Now, to show how, even while abiding in the way of reasoning, I have come under the power of the afflictions, it says:

People reap the fruits of their own actions;
all perish, without control: this I know.

And though I have examined and found that others are not at fault,

"People" are beings brought into birth by karma and the afflictions. "They reap the fruits of their own actions" means that they experience the ripened fruits, pleasant and unpleasant, of the actions done with their own body, speech, and mind. Therefore, even when they experience suffering that comes about with others as its condition, it is the fruit of actions they themselves committed, and so it is not the fault of others. And I also know that all are impermanent, since all sentient beings perish without any control of their own and are momentary by nature. Thus the pleasure and pain I experience arise from my own actions, and no fault lies with others. Though I have examined this with my intellect and know it to be my own fault, I am still unable to bear it, for my own mind is deluded, veiled by the darkness of ignorance. So the confusion, or the power, of being thoroughly deceived by the cataracts of unknowing is truly astonishing, and therefore it says:

Behold the confusion wrought by the cataracts of delusion!

To show that very confusion further, it says:

Though I am an ocean of faults,
I cannot bear even a fraction of anyone's fault.

Here, to begin with, I myself have faults that corrupt the continuum of body and mind, namely the afflictions such as desire and the nonvirtuous actions that arise from them, as many and as vast as an ocean. Yet I do not bear, and cannot endure, even the tiniest fraction, even a single drop, of a fault in anyone else at all: that is the great wonder of my mind.

Further, on the line,

Though patience has other excellent qualities,

patience is not merely the antidote to anger; it also has other boundless excellent qualities, such as bringing about a beautiful form. Or else it may be explained as "though others have patience, an excellent quality": that is, even though there are others endowed with good qualities who, in patience and moral discipline, have the excellent quality of patience.

The reason I am impatient is, here, the great wonder.

The meaning is this: the reason why, though the qualities of patience are boundless, I cannot rely on even a fraction of it and be patient, is this mind of

mine, deluded by nature; it is a wonder, something astonishing. "Though" shows how it appears contradictory, for it is a contradiction that, though I am an ocean of faults, I cannot bear faults, and that, though the qualities are boundless, I do not rely on those qualities.

To show how these very faults arise, it says:

Like the clouds that rise in the sky in the rainy season,
the massed clouds of affliction in my mind
come and go again and again.
Wretched am I, lazy, with all shame cast aside.

Just as in the rainy season masses of rain clouds gather and rise in the sky and then let fall their rain, so in the sky of my mind masses of afflictions such as desire arise suddenly; since they share the properties of clouds, they are cloud-like masses, that is, a great many of them arise. If one asks how they arise, that is the meaning of "they come and go again and again." Continually, again and again, they move to and fro and come back. Just as clouds gather in the sky, rise, drift, and pour down streams of water, so in my mind the afflictions constantly arise and swell, and having produced a rain of wrongdoing, they let it pour down. Therefore, though I know full well that I am possessed of such afflictions and that they arise, I have cast aside the quality of shame; I do not rely on diligence to abandon the afflictions, but have fallen under the power of laziness. So I myself am utterly wretched, deserving only of reproach.

To show that this runs counter to meditative absorption, the means of dispelling the afflictions, it says the passage beginning:

If the cold wind of the afflictions should arise,
though I am eager to conquer it with the blaze of absorption,

"Afflictions" are desire and the rest. They become the cause of harms such as broken moral discipline, and since they torment body and mind they are like a fierce cold wind. Just as, when the body is numbed by a cold wind, one cannot exert oneself, so, when one is stricken by the cold of the afflictions, one cannot enter the noble path; and so they are like the cold. Since they have arisen from ignorance as their cause, they must be removed from the mind stream. If one asks by what they are removed: by meditative absorption, that is, by making the mind one-pointed through cultivating the antidote. If one asks with what particular feature, it says "to conquer it with the blaze": with the blazing fire of gnosis kindled from the fire-drill of meditative concentration, the cold

wind of the afflictions is to be overpowered and subdued, for the likeness holds, just as fire is the antidote to cold. "Though I am eager" means: even though one is keen to do this and strives at it.

If one asks what fault arises when one strives in this way, it says:

the cataract of sleep and torpor grows so strong
that my longing for bed and seat increases too.

Sleep is the contraction of the mind whereby it functions without control. Torpor is that by which the mind grows dull and cannot properly apprehend its object. Since these two are causes of unknowing, they are a cataract. Their growing strong means that they arise with such force that they can overpower the mind's clarity. For that reason, "my longing for bed and seat increases too": through the force of sleep and torpor one cannot direct the mind to the object of meditative absorption; instead the mind turns to wanting, at all costs, to lie down on comfortable beds and seats, and laziness grows ever greater.

If one asks what comes of being thus unable to rely on the antidote to the afflictions, the text says:

My mind has been made helpless by the noose of desire.

Because my mind lacks meditative absorption, it has fallen under the power of the afflictions; therefore it is "made helpless by the noose of desire." As to this, desire is intense clinging and attachment to objects. Since that very thing is a tight bond, it is like a noose; and because it binds the mental continuum fast, without freedom, and leaves it no power to break loose, the text says "made helpless," meaning "rendered powerless."

As for "Burned by the fire of anger, crushed by the forms of pride": the fire of the mind's malice has burned up and consumed the virtues present in one's own continuum that accord with the noble path. "Crushed by the forms of pride" means that pride, excessive pride, and the rest have puffed up the mental continuum and stripped it of the riches of the noble ones.

If one asks whether it ends with these alone, it does not, for the text says:

By the arrows and spears, the weapons of all faults,
filled through and through, I have helplessly fallen into a swoon.

They are faults, and they are all of them; hence "of all faults," that is, the hosts of afflictions and secondary afflictions other than the afflictions already mentioned. These very afflictions are like arrows, because they are sharp and

because they pierce the mental continuum most subtly; and they are like spears, because they pierce in a coarse way and inflict grave harm. Whatever weapon is of that kind, by it the mental continuum is filled through and through. That is, like a weapon that has struck the body and stays lodged in it as a barb, and like one that cuts it on the outside, the hosts of afflictions, latent tendencies and manifest entanglements alike, pervade the mind. Owing to that cause, one is left without the power to exert oneself in the antidotal factors, and becomes utterly disheartened and unable to strive on the noble path; or else one becomes as though swooning and stupefied. That is the meaning.

To show still other faults of the mind's being overpowered by the afflictions, the text says:

Regaining mindfulness, I am bound and swiftly terrified;
utterly crushed, I have grown thoroughly disheartened;
and since dishonesty and pretense have deceived me as well,
I wander, feeble, through the domains of Māra.

Thus, overwhelmed by the afflictions, one remains as though in a swoon. Even when one comes back from that and once more regains the mindfulness in which the mind is settled in its natural state, one is bound again by the afflictions and falls under their power, and for that very reason one is swiftly terrified. That is, the mind does not stay long in its natural, settled state; it is stirred up and terrified by the weapons of the hosts of afflictions, and because it is utterly crushed and overwhelmed, it becomes thoroughly disheartened, unable to exert itself toward the object of meditative absorption, and is left without capacity. For that very reason, since the mind has come under the power of adverse factors, afflictions such as dishonesty and pretense arise as well; these deceive the mind, and it loses the noble path. And so the mind, bereft of the strength of the antidotes, is weak in capacity and feeble, and because of this, through the power of unknowing, it dwells within the domain of Māra, the hosts of afflictions, and wanders for a long time to no purpose. That is the meaning.

To show that, when one cultivates calm abiding and insight in order to clear away such afflictions, one is unable to direct the mind, the text says:

However I focus on calm abiding
and fix my mind upon those objects again and again,
from each of them the noose of the afflictions

drags it helplessly away with the rope of attachment to objects.

In whatever manner one abides in what is called calm abiding, the mode of meditative concentration that is one-pointed upon its object of focus, and the mind focuses upon it; and even when, in order to attain that one-pointedness, one directs the mind again and again to this or that object of meditative absorption, whichever it may be, and trains in one-pointedness, it does not come to rest that way. For from each of those objects of focus, the entrenched afflictions, like a tight noose, drag the mental continuum helplessly back out from being directed inward upon the object of focus, using something like a rope: the mind's turning to gaze outward through intense attachment and clinging to the five objects of desire. And so it becomes distracted.

What this shows is the following. When, to clear away the hosts of conceptual thoughts, one draws the mind inward by the power of calm abiding and with wisdom directs it to its object, phenomena void of intrinsic nature and free of conceptual thought, even then, stirred by the hosts of afflictions, it falls under the sway of objects experienced before, and they distract it. That is the meaning.

Suppose one says, "Even if that happens, one can surely apply effort to hold to the object and so settle the mind in equipoise." To show that it is hard to remain like that, the text says:

If I apply exertion, excitement arises.

Exertion here refers to engaging intently, with eager delight, in the side of virtue. It does not refer to effort that springs from the motivation of desire and anger, such as the effort to bring back Sītā and Draupadī, as told in the tales of the Rāmāyaṇa and the Bhārata. So here, when one relies on and persists in the application of diligence, the antidote to laziness, the mind falls away from calm through that effort, and so it grows excited and flighty, turned outward.

Suppose one says, "In that case, one may as well give up exertion." The text says:

If I give it up, laxity is born.
When for this mind a proper balance is hard to find,
what am I to do with my troubled mind?

If, seeing the fault of growing excited, one gives up that exertion and lets effort go, the mind sinks inward, and no directing of it to the object of focus

arises. Therefore, for this mind possessed of afflictions, to abide evenly poised, free of both the modes of excitement and laxity, is for the mind to enter properly into balance; but because that is so very hard to find and attain, the text says, "What am I to do with my mind," unstable and troubled by the hosts of afflictions. That is, either way it turns into a fault and is without stability, so what am I to engage it in? That is the meaning.

Suppose one says, "Since the matter of what to abandon and what to adopt is accomplished by wisdom, one should rely on that." For this reason the text says:

If I engage in wisdom, excitement arises;
if I rely on holding, laxity is born.
When for this mind union is hard to find,

Wisdom is the thorough investigation of the general and specific characteristics of phenomena, comprehensively and exactly as they are. If one engages in such wisdom, excitement arises; that is, the mind roams among its various objects and so cannot become calm. If, abandoning that, one comes to rely solely on holding the mind, fixing it on some object of calm abiding, whatever it may be, and drawing it inward, then, because it is parted from wisdom and withdrawn from objects, it is bereft of wisdom's aspect of clarity, and so laxity arises in the mind as it turns inward.

That being so, as for "union" for this flawed mind: calm abiding and insight abiding in equal measure is called "union." It is like this. Just as, when the yoke of a pair of oxen sits evenly balanced, they can break open well even very hard fields, so when the mind abides with calm abiding and insight in equal measure, like a lamp unstirred by the wind, then the gnosis that casts off the hosts of afflictions arises. But for a beginner's mind that union is extremely hard to find, and one cannot abide like that. For that very reason, because the mind has fallen under the power of the afflictions, the text says:

What am I to do with my troubled mind?

Since my mind, lacking calm abiding and insight, cannot stay engaged, how am I to employ it, troubled and distracted as it has become, and what am I to accomplish with it? That is the meaning.

Suppose one says, "Then one can surely engage in that very aim through effort alone." The text says:

If I engage with striving, excitement arises,
and if I relax it, laxity is born.

When, so that the mind may abide in the manner of union and the rest, one engages and strives, exerting oneself intently with the utmost striving, that mind becomes excited and distracted; overpowered by this, one does not find stability of mind even through effort. Since that is thus a fault, if, to counter it, one relaxes that mind engaged through striving and lets go of effort, then through faults such as forgetting the object of focus the mind shrinks inward and sinking arises; so from remaining in this way, too, no mind one-pointed in meditative absorption is born. Therefore the text says:

When for this mind keeping to the middle way, too, is hard to find,

For this mind, thus possessed of the faults of excitement and laxity, "keeping to the middle way," that is, keeping to the middle by being free of both extremes, laxity and excitement, and abiding in balance, is also extremely hard to find; for the mind is by its nature hard to tame, and so it is always under the power of adverse factors. Therefore the text says:

what am I to do with my troubled mind?

Although the mind is by its intrinsic nature pure and luminous, it has been stirred up and made turbid by the hosts of adventitious afflictions, so that the reflection of true reality cannot appear in it or be seen; that being so, "how am I to abide and to practice?" This is a confession made by declaring the faults of the mind itself.

Now, to show that the root of the faults is the grasping at self that springs from ignorance, the text says:

Though again and again, by the forest fire of meditative concentration,

Meditative concentration is the mind's being in meditative equipoise, that is, the four meditative concentrations and so on. Since it burns up and consumes the thickets of the afflictions, it is like a great fire spreading through a forest. By such a fire, "again and again," that is, at each and every instant. If one asks what it does, the text says:

the forest of faults has been burned,

The faults are desire and the rest. Because they are many and are the fuel to be burned, they are like a forest; and even though this has been burned and cleared away by the fire of meditative concentration,

since the firm root, the view of self, is not exhausted,

Grasping at self and at what belongs to self, being the ground from which the afflictions arise, is like a root, and having come down from beginningless time, it is extremely firm. Since genuine wisdom has not exhausted it or torn it out by the roots, it springs up again in full force. If one asks in what way, the text says:

as if moistened by rain, they flourish before me.

Just as, in summer, trees that have been burned, if their roots have not been scorched and pulled out, grow again when they meet with moisture, so the view of self is the root of all faults; if it has not been abandoned, then whenever the condition of an object is present, the afflictions arise manifestly in active operation, as though standing right before one.

Suppose one says, "Since the root of the afflictions is cleared away even by seeing that the person has no self, that much of the wisdom aspect suffices." The text says:

Even by seeing what is a mere stream of afflictions, karma, and results,
that view is turned back; and

Afflictions are desire, anger, and the like. Karma is of the nature of the virtuous, the nonvirtuous, and the indeterminate. Results are karmic maturation. The word "mere" serves to deny Īśvara (the Lord, held by some to be the creator) and the like: there is only the result of afflictions and karma, and apart from that there is no agent. The stream of these is what occurs as an unbroken series of instants. When a yogin who sees and investigates this sees it with wisdom endowed with mindfulness and vigilance, that view of self is indeed turned back; for when one examines it, the stream of saṃsāra arises solely from karma and afflictions alone, and apart from these, nothing called a "self" is established.

Not only is that view turned back: "though one also abandons the stream of mind." Suppose it is said that the noble śrāvakas abandon, in the manner of an adverse factor and its antidote, the stream of mind that abides as a succession of instants, namely that aggregate of consciousness which has the nature of the truth of suffering and is conceived as a real substance, because the truth of the path, focused on the truth of cessation called "the emptiness of consciousness," has arisen as its antidote. Then, having become of the very nature of emptiness, they apprehend neither self nor others, and so they are

"very far from striving for the welfare of beings." That is, because they lack the special wisdom that sees things as neither solely empty nor solely nonempty, they are disheartened by suffering while dwelling in saṃsāra, and so they are unable to bring the welfare of others to completion. That is the meaning.

If one asks how they are far from the welfare of beings, the text says:

Since the protectors are wholly free of even mere attachment,

"Protectors" refers to those who protect their own continuum by means of the Dharma endowed with the four noble truths, or to those worthy of offerings: the noble arhats. They are free of "even mere attachment": being free of even the mere craving that clings to beings in saṃsāra, and having abandoned it, they are wholly free of it. Further:

who have become without regard for all beings,

They are beings, and they are all; hence "all beings," that is, all who belong to the three realms. To have become without regard for them is to have abandoned the effort born of regard, of setting out to draw them out of saṃsāra and free them from suffering; that is, these are the ones devoted to their own welfare. To show that their stream of mind passes into nirvāṇa, the text says:

the stream of mind, like a lamp whose cause is spent,
passes into a nirvāṇa where the remaining aggregates are exhausted.

Here, mind is of the nature of consciousness. Its stream is the series handed on from one instant to the next. When that stream has been purified by gnosis and has undergone a transformation of its basis, it is "like a lamp whose cause is spent": just as a lamp no longer burns once its cause, the oil, is exhausted, so, through the gnosis that arises from the vajra-like meditative absorption, they abandon the afflictions together with their habitual tendencies, and so pass into nirvāṇa. That, moreover, is nirvāṇa without remainder: even the mere residual aggregates that still remain, produced by former karma and afflictions, are burned by the fire of gnosis, exhausted and made nonexistent, and they come to abide in the expanse of nirvāṇa. Therefore they are very far from working for the welfare of beings. That is the meaning.

Now, to show that, when the welfare of beings of this kind comes from the awakening mind, one's own continuum is out of harmony with it, the text says, in the passage that begins:

That which dispels the misery of all beings,

"That which" is the awakening mind. If one asks what qualities it possesses, the text says:

that dispels the misery of beings, leaving none out,

It dispels without exception, and brings to an end, the torment of the three kinds of suffering and the misery of all sentient beings, comprised in the four modes of birth, who dwell anywhere up to the Peak of Existence. If one asks what it is that is like this, the text says:

the awakening mind is nectar and rejuvenating elixir.

It is the awakening mind whose nature is aspiring to awakening and engaging in it. If one asks how it is distinguished, the text says, "nectar and rejuvenating elixir." Just as one who eats nectar cannot be overcome by death, so the awakening mind sustains the life of the noble path and brings about the attainment of every exalted state; therefore it is like nectar. And just as taking the medicine of rejuvenating elixir removes white hair and wrinkles and frees one from illness, so the awakening mind destroys the suffering and afflictions that belong to the continua of oneself and others.

Precisely because it has such qualities, it must be put into practice; therefore the text says:

When I cultivate nonconceptuality as the cause of awakening,

Awakening is the gnosis of the knowledge of all aspects. "When I cultivate nonconceptuality" as the cause and the basis for attaining it means: when one trains in bringing to mind the reality free of conceptual elaboration, in a way that wholly abandons the apprehended and the apprehender. If one asks whether the mind then abides in that way, it does not, for the text says:

at that time I run only after conceptual thoughts.

That is, it is at the time when one is training in order to accomplish the great gnosis of the awakening mind that the text says, "at that time I run only after conceptual thoughts." Because I am a beginner, my mind runs only after conceptual thoughts. "Conceptual thoughts": the meaning is that it runs after, and turns toward, the many improper conceptual thoughts produced by unreal imagination. The word "only" rules out other modes. Therefore, since it is not the domain of anything else, only conceptual thoughts rest on the ground of the mind, and nothing else does; just as one says, "Only Arjuna is the bearer of the bow; the others are not."

Here someone asks: "That is not reasonable, for it has been taught:

Rivers, oceans, and mountains:
all these are the mind's magical displays.

Since there is nothing at all apart from the mind, it is not tenable to set up a support and what it supports." That is so; but since, in the system of the Sautrāntikas, both the object and the mind are held to be established, there is no contradiction.

To show other ways in which, even while remaining in meditation, one has been unable to clear away conceptual thought, the text says:

All beings being like a dream, where no one at all
takes hold of anything whatsoever,

"Dream" refers to that which, owing to causes in what was previously experienced, can appear even though it does not exist; it is deception itself. Thus in a dream, objects of attachment, such as the loveliest woman in the land, or objects of aversion, such as an enemy, appear even though they do not exist. "Like" means being of the same manner as that. If one asks what is of the same manner, it is "beings," that is, the things that dwell in this coreless abode of saṃsāra. If one asks in what way they are alike: "no one at all takes hold of anything whatsoever." That is, among beings, no conceptual thought, no apprehender whatsoever, seizes or takes up any entity at all, subtle or coarse, of the kind called an object or something to be apprehended.

It is just as in a dream: one sees many kinds of objects, pleasant and unpleasant, and they become objects of clinging; yet because they are by nature delusion, in reality nothing at all exists.

even though I meditate, I roam within the very domain
of that enemy, conceptual thought of conceiver and conceived.

The meaning of the word "even" is this: it is not only that I have heard and understood that all phenomena are like a dream; even though I have meditated on that meaning again and again and grown familiar with it, I have fallen under the power of conceptual thought. If one asks what that conceptual thought is like, the text says "of conceiver and," and so on. Because it conceives, it is the "conceiver," the mind that apprehends. Because it is what is to be conceived and understood, it is the "conceived," the objects to be apprehended. Whatever thought conceives of these as existent is "conceptual thought of conceiver and conceived"; that is, the thoughts that conceive in

terms of apprehended and apprehender. Because that very thing is the side adverse to selflessness and nonconceptuality, it is an "enemy." Within what has become the very domain of such an enemy, conceptual thought, I constantly roam; I have fallen under its power, or been vanquished by it. That is, even though I know things to be false like a dream, and have drawn my mind back from objects and meditated, I am vanquished by the hosts of conceptual thoughts that go back to beginningless time. That is the meaning.

Having understood in this way that conceptual thought is hard to turn back and that one's own antidote is feeble, then, to show that one supplicates the Blessed One himself, the text says:

O Lord, look upon this torment, so utterly unbearable,
and grant me a stainless view.

"Lord" is a form of address. He is the Lord because he has gained mastery over all phenomena, or because he heals the diseases of the afflictions. "This torment, so utterly unbearable": in my own mental continuum, harm has arisen from the stream of afflictions such as desire; it torments the continuum of body and mind both now and in the long run, fierce and utterly unbearable, and it is plainly present. "Look upon this, and grant me a stainless view" means: "Grant me the correct view, the medicine for these torments, unsullied by the stains of adverse factors and faults."

Suppose one says, "Surely one can generate these by the strength of one's own effort." The text says:

Whatever I hold dear and whatever I examine,
that very thing falls to ruin at the very outset.

That is, whatever antidotal path I set about examining and investigating, in accord with what is to be held dear and treasured as essential, the immeasurables or the perfections, that very path falls to ruin and perishes at the very outset. This is what it teaches. In substance, whatever antidote one relies on in order to vanquish the hosts of afflictions, it is so feeble that it is overwhelmed by the adverse side. That is the meaning.

Now, to show that these flaws are one's own fault, the text says:

Or rather, the fault is my own, committed in former lives:
what could the Blessed One do about this?

"Or rather" is to be construed thus: "Since this is a fault that comes from myself, what is there for him to do?" If one asks when the fault was

committed: "in former lives," that is, because in former lives, handed down from beginningless time, it was produced by unreal imagination, and so was accumulated as the habitual tendencies of the distortions. If one asks what "this" is: it is this fault of mine, this flawed condition full of faults, such as falling under the sway of what is wrong even while relying on the antidote, holding it as essential, and pursuing it. The Blessed One is the one who has vanquished the four Māras, or the one endowed with the six excellences beginning with lordship; that is, the Buddha. "What could you, such a Blessed One, do?" means that it is hard to remedy. To fall under the power of the afflictions and wander in the domain of Māra is one's own fault; and since beings are the owners of their karma, they experience only the results of the karma they themselves have done. The maker of happiness and suffering is not the Blessed One. That is why a sūtra too says, "I am the field, not the seed."

To show this same point by an example, the text says:

Even with the sun that dispels the darkness of all the world,

Because it is the world and it is all, it is "all the world." Since the sun illumines everything alike, this refers to the world of both moving and unmoving things. Their darkness is the murk in which there is no light, and whatever dispels and destroys it is called its dispeller. If one asks who that is, it is the sun, the thousand-rayed. Even with a sun possessed of such qualities,

those born blind do not dispel the black darkness.

Those born blind are those who have been blind from the very moment of birth. They do not dispel and destroy the black darkness; yet that is not the fault of the sun, but comes from the fault of the blind themselves. In the same way, even though the Buddha, the Blessed One, the sun of Dharma, acts with the rays of the sublime Dharma, comprising the three baskets of scripture, to destroy the darkness of unknowing that dwells in the hearts of beings, that he does not clear away the faults of those who cling to wrong views and lack the eye of wisdom is the fault of those beings themselves, and not of the Teacher.

Having thus stated the nature of one's own faults, to show further how hard they are to cure by the noble path, the text says:

Who has long relied upon the causes of disease,
whose mind is ever deluded about them too,
for such a leper, whose feet and hands have fallen away,

what can a few moments of taking medicine achieve?

This is to be construed as: "For one in the grip of incurable leprosy, what can medicine achieve?" If one asks what kind of leper, the text says, "who has long relied upon the causes of disease." That is, he relies and dwells for a long time upon those causes of disease: the actions that produce leprosy, such as destroying the sacred supports of the Three Jewels, and unsuitable food, conduct, and the like. And even as he does so, "about them too," about the causes of disease, his mind is always and continually deluded, so that he does not persist even for a few moments in applying the means to clear them away. "Too" means that he not only relies on the causes of disease but also clings to them in his mind.

If one asks what else he is like: "whose feet and hands have fallen away." Because he has thus dwelt in the causes of disease and has not had them treated, the leprosy spreads through his whole body, until in the end even his feet and hands break off and crumble away. For such a leper, even if for a few moments he takes and eats medicine that is good for leprosy, it does not bring about a cure; hence the text says, "what can it achieve?" The meaning is that it will not make him free of disease.

In the same way, the cause of the disease of the afflictions in one's own continuum is the view of self. One dwells in that view for a long time and clings to it intensely as well, and one does not even seek the noble path as its antidote. For those who have thus become incurable, the true path does not perform the work of a path. That is the import.

Further, to show by other examples as well how this comes from one's own faults, the text says, in the passage that begins:

The tree of the mind, which belongs to beginningless time,

Mind is the group of consciousnesses. Since in the example it is like a tree, it is a "tree." If one asks since what time it has existed: "which belongs to beginningless time." It is without beginning and it is time; hence "beginningless time." "Belonging to time" refers to what is measured out by the sun, the moon, the planets, the stars, and so forth; and since saṃsāra too is without beginning, it is so called. If one asks what has made that tree grow through such a span of time:

steeped in the bitter juice of the afflictions,

The afflictions are desire and the rest. These are ignoble, and when tasted they are noxious and unpalatable; therefore they are a bitter juice, like the juice of neem and the like. Being moistened with such juice, the tree is made to grow and flourish, and for that very reason it

cannot be made into a thing of sweet taste;

Just as a bitter-tasting tree that has been watered and raised on water that is itself bitter cannot be given a nature that is sweet and so forth, so the nature of the mind, produced by the afflictions, is hard to transform by the noble path. That is the meaning. If one asks by how much it could be changed:

what can a drop of the water of good qualities do?

What will come of pouring onto such a tree a single drop of water possessing the eight qualities, such as sweetness? It will not all turn sweet. In the same way, for me, the nature of whose mind, produced by afflictions that belong to beginningless time, is hard to transform and correct by the true path, a mere drop of the antidotal Dharma, water with good qualities such as sweetness, does not cleanse the hosts of afflictions and give rise to the qualities of the noble path. That is the meaning.

Further, to show the faults of the door of the mind, the text says:

My mind is the very nature of all faults.

Because my mind is stirred up by the hosts of afflictions, it lacks the discernment of what to abandon and what to adopt, and so it abides as the nature, or the very essence, of all faults: the faults such as desire and anger, which bring harm in this life and the next. And since the supreme antidote that clears away those faults is the awakening mind, the text says:

Awakening has become a gold-making elixir, a great marvel;
yet though applied to that very thing, with those good qualities,
it remains, become the very substance of faults.

Awakening is unsurpassed gnosis. The mind that attains it is also called "awakening," by giving the cause the name of the result. It is like a gold-making elixir. Just as a gold-making elixir, the one called "quicksilver that appears as gold," transforms iron into gold, so the awakening mind purifies the afflicted mind of saṃsāra and turns it into genuine gnosis; therefore it is like a gold-making elixir. That is, it is "the mind that is the gnosis of the Omniscient One." For that very reason it is "a great marvel," that is, wondrous. Such an awakening mind possesses many kinds of hosts of good qualities; yet even

when the mind is applied to that very thing, and one sets about purifying the mental continuum through generating the awakening mind and so forth, it does not engage in harmony with it; therefore "it remains, become the very substance of faults." The import is this: even when it is applied to the awakening mind, adorned with both worldly and world-transcending good qualities, because it has fallen under the power of the afflictions, it remains, having taken up and held fast to the very substance of the faults of body, speech, and mind, which has become its nature. Like the mind of a drunken man, it cannot retain good qualities; rather, having become nothing but a source of faults, it stays that way.

The meaning of this in brief is as follows. Just as iron and the like, if not thoroughly refined, do not give up their own substance even when smeared with the gold-making elixir, so this unrefined mind, too, even when applied to the good qualities of the awakening mind, does not cast off its own faults and flaws.

Now, to show the right method itself for that gold-making elixir of awakening, the text says:

Whatever has been taught as a great medicine,
that very thing has become poison for me.

Because it cures the disease of the afflictions, it is a "great medicine": whatever has been explained and taught as the antidotal path through the doors of Dharma such as loving-kindness, that is, whatever paths have been taught, such as the unattractive as the antidote to desire, loving-kindness as the antidote to anger, and dependent origination as the antidote to delusion. "That very thing has become poison for me": not for others. Rather, precisely those sublime medicines have become poison for me, because I alone am ill-fated and have fallen under the power of the afflictions. Just as, through causes such as faulty administration, medicine brings death, or gives rise to a disease that ends in death, so for me that medicine of the Dharma turns into its opposite and gives rise to afflictions; therefore it is said to "have become poison."

If one asks by what one who remains in that state is to be cured, the text says:

If right method itself is the supreme elixir,

To abandon the afflictions by way of seeking the right path for the mind, or of abiding steadfastly in meditative concentration and absorption, or of abiding

through faith and investigating with wisdom, and so forth: this is the right method. And that right method, it is explained, rests upon the sublime Dharma spoken by the Blessed One.

"If it is the supreme elixir": following and putting into practice the speech of the Teacher dispels the sickness of the afflictions and is the cause of freedom from the suffering of saṃsāra. Since it is therefore far superior to ordinary elixirs, it is supreme.

If that is so, by what is it obtained? To this the text says:

If confidence is lacking, it is not there.

That is to say, if one has fallen under the power of the afflictions and lacks confidence, being without faith in the path and without certainty, then that right method is not there either. When one engages with faith in accomplishing buddhahood, one comes to be liberated: if one has faith, one generates the mind set on awakening, and from that one is gradually liberated. This is a reason based on intrinsic nature (svabhāvahetu).

Alternatively, "confidence" refers to mental happiness. Where the bliss of the samādhi of one-pointed mind that comes from settling in meditative equipoise arises, together with mental happiness, there the right method able to abandon the afflictions will also be present. But in one who lacks that mental happiness and whose mind is distracted, that right method is not present, and so one is simply overcome by the afflictions.

Now, in order to show what right method itself is, the text states the passage beginning "That which dispels the surging afflictions." Here, since right method is the abandoning of the afflictions:

That which dispels the surging afflictions
And gives rise to no other fault,
This is right method, so I think;

What right method should one possess? To abandon the afflictions such as attachment, aversion and delusion, which have arisen surging up and running rampant, each by its own particular antidote, is not the sublime method, for that turns out as was shown above. Therefore the antidote to the cause of the afflictions is right thought, in which wrong thinking and analysis have been pacified. If, on the path of joining, one grows familiar with that noble path, the instruction reflected upon, through attention grounded in conviction, then through the seeing of reality it pacifies the host of afflictions before long. And

it also does not stir up or agitate the faults of the host of afflictions that, apart from those that are manifestly active, remain in the mind-stream as latent tendencies, nor other faults that arise incidentally, as when aversion arises while one meditates on the unattractive as the antidote to attachment. That antidotal path is what is called right method. Since it does not contradict valid cognition and possesses a reason that gives rise to correct gnosis, I think in my mind and know with my understanding that such is right method;

Yet I have not gone on to ascertain what it is like.

To have realized it in direct perception by meditating on the path of that right method which is the cause of liberation, and so to have attained gnosis, is what ascertaining means. Since I have not attained that, it says, "Yet I have not gone on to ascertain what it is like," meaning, "I have not made myself familiar with that path of right method." It shows: "Although I have come to know the correct path taught by the Teacher through the wisdom born of hearing and reflection, I have not realized it in direct perception through the wisdom born of meditation."

Having shown the result of the awakening mind, the text now, in order to show the result of meditation, says:

Intentions, latent tendencies, elements and imprints:
Applying oneself to the antidotes to these causes of faults,
When one meditates on that instruction reflected upon,
Here, before long, they will be pacified.

"Intention" is the deep-seated intention, that is, the mind. "Latent tendencies" are the proclivities, such as attachment. "Elements" means one's intrinsic nature. "Imprints": these very things, intention and the rest, remain in the mind as imprints. Whatever faults there are in the mind that have come from the imprints of intentions, latent tendencies and elements, whatever causes there are, such as the view of a self, from which attachment, aversion and the like arise: to their antidote, that is, to what stands opposed to them, selflessness or impurity and the like, one applies the mind and continually relies on it. And that "instruction reflected upon" is the meaning of the distinctions between the vehicles that the Teacher taught with the gradation of superior, middling and lesser faculties in mind, or of the separate antidotes to attachment, aversion and delusion that he taught, made certain through the wisdom born of hearing and reflection. When one meditates on that instruction reflected upon in order to realize it in direct perception, and becomes familiar

with it, then, from making the mind one-pointed, that host of afflictions comes to be pacified.

If one asks how soon this happens, the text says:

Here, before long, they will be pacified.

At this stage, by meditating well on this way of the instruction and attending to it, the host of afflictions present in the mind is cleared away and pacified swiftly, before long. The meaning is that for those who have entered by abiding correctly in meditation, the afflictions are not hard to abandon.

Now, to show that the speech of the Blessed One is itself undeceiving, the text says:

The Protector, wholly free from every fault,

"Protector": he is the protector because he protects sentient beings from suffering. "Faults" are the phenomena of saṃsāra, such as attachment; he is free from all of them, having abandoned them. If one asks what else he is like, the text says:

Who sees the sublime meaning of all phenomena,

They are phenomena and they are all; hence "all phenomena," whether defiled or undefiled, moving or unmoving, near or far. The sublime meaning of those phenomena is their uncommon meaning. Since he has the nature of one who sees it, he is called "one who sees the sublime meaning of all phenomena."

Since you have taught definitively in various ways,

This means that, since faculties and inclinations are various, he taught by definitively distinguishing many ways of the vehicles; or, since the forms of the afflictions are endless, he taught the ways of the antidotes as various as well. Whatever he taught in this way abandons the entire host of afflictions, such as attachment, together with their imprints, without remainder; hence:

It clears away the seeds of the afflictions without remainder.

The meaning is that it clears away all the afflictions of the three realms without remainder.

Having thus explained the qualities of the teaching, now, in order to show how the afflictions are abandoned through seeing the form body and hearing the speech, the praise speaks the passage beginning:

When your body, ablaze with the beautiful marks,
Is seen dwelling there before one, and

Blessed One, your form body is distinguished by the beautiful marks, called beautiful marks because they are both beautiful and marks: the thirty-two marks, such as the crown protuberance on the head, and the eighty excellent minor marks. For that very reason it blazes, brilliant, resplendent and radiant, and its complexion, like gold from the Jambū River, blazes intensely. Such a body is "dwelling before one" when it is seen in sensory direct perception, or when the mind sees it as though it were present to mental direct perception and makes it vividly present. And further:

The nectar to be drunk with the ears is heard as well,

Since it is to be drunk by persons with their two ears, it is "drunk with the ears"; the meaning is "taken in with the ears." If one asks what is drunk: "the nectar is heard as well." The words "as well" are conjunctive: Protector, not only are the afflictions cleared away by seeing your body directly or by focusing on it as present to the mind; your speech, too, becomes nectar for whatever person hears it. Just as those who drink nectar from their cupped hands become invulnerable to death, so those who take in the nectar of the Protector's speech, as if drinking it from the cupped hands of their two ears, cannot be harmed by the poison of the afflictions; and since the life faculty of their virtue is not cut off, they do not go to the lower realms.

The seeds of the afflictions are utterly destroyed, without remainder.

This means that the afflictions of a person who sees such a body and hears that speech, afflictions that make one circle through the three realms and that produce suffering, are utterly destroyed, entirely and without remainder, together with their seeds; of themselves they depart and are exhausted.

Having thus explained the qualities of seeing the form body, now, in order to show the qualities of seeing the dharmakāya, it speaks the passage beginning:

Lord, you have what is more supreme than that:

"Lord" is a form of address. "You have what is more supreme than that" is to be construed as: "You also possess a body far more excellent and supreme than that form body, a body not shared with others." If one asks what that is:

The dharmakāya too, the unsurpassed sun,

The word "dharma" expresses that, since the Blessed One has the essential nature of the Dharma, this body is extremely subtle; and it shows that it cannot be pointed out, that it does not appear in any way, and that it is the domain of the Omniscient One alone. That itself is the body: since it is both dharma and body, it is the dharma body; it is to be construed as a descriptive compound (karmadhāraya). Since it is like the sun, it is the sun of the Dharma: for just as the sun clears away the mass of outer darkness, so the light of the wisdom of the dharmadhātu (the sphere of reality) destroys the pitch darkness of ignorance, and in this it shares the nature of the sun. For that very reason it is unsurpassed: because there is nothing else beyond it, or because it is not shared with anyone on the lower grounds. Therefore it says:

Which, even when contemplated, does not become the domain of beings,

Even though they contemplate and meditate on the very essence of the dharmakāya, it does not become the domain of the beings of the three realms, ordinary people who cling to things as real, because their minds do not realize and comprehend its intrinsic nature. If one asks how it is known to exist in this way, it says:

Destroying the cataract of faults: great is the wonder!

Because that which, like the sun, destroys and clears away the cataract of the black darkness of the fault called ignorance, the root of the afflictions, is the dharmakāya, the wisdom of emptiness. Though it is not apprehended as a thing and has not become a domain of the eye, it clears away the darkness of people's minds: that is a great wonder. It is marvelous because it is an inconceivable domain.

Then, by way of concluding the confession and praise that have thus been composed, and in order to show the homage paid by proclaiming the qualities of the Blessed One, it says:

By that supreme mind, whatever it may be,

This is to be construed with "Blessed One, I bow and pay homage to you." If one asks why homage is paid: because you bring faults to peace. If one asks by what means: "By that supreme mind, whatever it may be," that is, by that supreme mind, whatever it may be, with which you have realized the nondual wisdom that is not the domain of śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and the like. If one asks what its focus is, it says:

Abiding in that calm abiding, whatever it may be,

Homage to you who abide in the spontaneously accomplished union of calm abiding and insight, or in the vajra-like samādhi, and who, having entered the supreme meditative concentration, abide in the attainment of having reached the culmination of yoga. If one asks why that is, it says:

You who bring all faults to peace in every way:
To the Blessed One, whoever he is, homage!

It is you who act to pacify and clear away all the faults that produce the suffering of saṃsāra; the meaning is that you turn them back. If one asks how: "in every way," that is, you clear them away in every respect, together with their imprints; or else you pacify them by every means, that is, through the various ways of the vehicles, or through the various avenues of skillful means such as magical powers and miracles. Therefore: "To the Blessed One, whoever he may be, homage." The meaning is: to the Blessed One who brings such a host of faults to peace, I bow and pay homage with body, speech and mind, with faith and devotion. The words "whoever he is" are spoken as the words of one whom your knowledge does not pervade; were it otherwise, it would not be proper to speak so to the Lord. So the meaning is: "To you who possess such qualities, whoever you may be, I pay homage and go for refuge."

Now, in order to dedicate to sentient beings whatever merit has come from composing the praise, and, since that is the training of bodhisattvas, to act in accord with it, he says the lines beginning, "Thus, with confession to the one of unsurpassed qualities." "Thus" signals completion. "The one of unsurpassed qualities" is he who possesses an uncommon host of qualities, that is, the Teacher. "Confession to him" means declaring in his presence whatever misdeeds and faults one has committed oneself. What, then, has been done by such means? He says, "the virtue of composing true praise." That is, from words of true praise to the Blessed One, amplified and well composed by way of declaring one's own faults, comes virtue, that is, the merit that has been made. What is it like? He says, "white as the lovely moon, whatever I have gathered, by it." That merit is white and lovely like the autumn moon: unmixed with the dark stains of wrongdoing, and pleasing to the mind. "Whatever I have gathered" means what I myself have accomplished, the accumulation I have fully gathered. By mentioning the moon, he also shows that his own name is Candra, which means "moon." And by mentioning whiteness, he shows that his own nature is pure. To what is that merit dedicated? He says, "May all beings go to Sukhāvatī." That is: by the merit I have thus gathered, may all these beings go to the world realm of Sukhāvatī (the Land of Bliss) and

be born there. Alternatively, the unsurpassed bliss is buddhahood, and the meaning is: may they attain the state endowed with that bliss.

At the request
Of the great-minded Sumati,
I, Buddhaśānti,
Have made this commentary on the Confession Praise.

Through Candra's words and meaning, vast in scope,
This profound conduct of the Sugata
Was composed in the manner of praise after confession,
In order to purify existence.

By this commentary on it that I have made,
Pleasing to the mind like the rays of the moon,
May the afflictions of beings be purified,
And may they attain flawless buddhahood.

The Commentary on the Confession Praise, composed by the master Buddhaśānti, is complete. It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Buddhaśrīśānti and the chief editor-translator, the monk Rinchen Zangpo.

Translator's Notes

• In the explanation of the first verse the lemma reads nyes par dmigs nas, an evident slip for nye bar dmigs nas ("turning my mind to"), as in the root verse; a few words are also accidentally repeated in the sentence on the connection, and are translated once. The source of the closing quotation, given as lan chu bo'i mdo, could not be identified; it is rendered by its apparent meaning, "Salt River Sūtra". The four topics named after the first verse (subject matter, connection, purpose, and the purpose of the purpose) are the standard preliminaries of an Indian commentary.
• In the first citation of the root verse the second line reads "pool" (rdzing), but the commentary's own repetition of that line reads "boat" (gzings) and explains it as the boat that is the means of crossing the ocean of attachment; "pool" is evidently a copyist's slip, perhaps prompted by the "pool of loving-kindness" in the next verse, so "boat" is translated in both places. In "mental continuum," rgyud means the stream of mind (santāna), not tantra.
• Three evident scribal slips are read as follows. Before "If to that end I rely on the conventional," the text has ci'i phyir, "why?"; it is read as de'i phyir, "for this reason," the commentary's regular formula for introducing a root line. In the summary, brnyes, "obtained," is read as brnyas, "contempt," as the sūtra's "destroys all respect" confirms. In the sūtra verse, mya ngan, "sorrow," is read as mya ngam, "desert," which the parallel with the winter cold of the snowy mountains plainly requires.
• In the root line "Even if through faith I make it clear once more," the text reads dad byas, "made faithful," where the commentary's gloss ("makes it clear and free of turbidity") shows the reading dang byas, "made clear"; that reading is translated. The verse on self and other is

a well-known verse of Dharmakīrti's Pramāṇavārttika; the text names its author tshogs kyi grags pa, evidently a slip for chos kyi grags pa, the standard Tibetan rendering of Dharmakīrti, and it is translated accordingly.
• A few evident scribal slips are translated in their plain readings: mtshan ma, "sign," as mtshan mo, "night," in the explanation of the Night of Kāla, which the relative clause requires; sred, "crave," as sreg, "burn," in "remorse that can burn the mental continuum" (the commentary uses this same image of burning the mental continuum earlier); and 'dri, cing and mod as 'dra ("just as"), cir ("what") and med ("without"). In "the dark side," the commentary plays on the Tibetan, which means both Māra's side and the dark, waning half of the lunar month.
• Here drag po is the adjective "fierce," qualifying aversion, and dus is "time"; neither is the name Rudra or Kāla. The commentary says that the serpents "whose glance is venom" cannot kill by a mere glance but can make one faint with their venomous breath; this is translated as it stands, though the epithet usually denotes serpents that kill with a look. In the cited verse on self-reproach, the verb bas par yields no sense and is read as bsal bar, "cleared away." "The power of repudiation" is one of the four powers of confession.
• In the quoted root verse, the line rendered "Fevered" is written rim nya bcas in the Tibetan; the commentary's own gloss, rims dang bcas pa, "fevered," shows the intended reading. Two other evident slips are read the same way: rme as rma, "wound," and pos as bos, "having called out."
• In the verses as quoted here, the second line reads □□□□□□□ ("afraid") and the line on sleep and torpor reads □□□ ("pleasant"); the commentary's own glosses (perishing and momentary; arising with great force) show that its text read □□□□□□ and □□□, and the verses are translated accordingly. □□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□.
The definition of sleep follows the Abhidharma definition of middha as the contraction of the mind, functioning without control. The commentator also glosses the verse's "conquer" (□□□□□□) with the similar-sounding "subdue, overpower" (□□□□□□□).
• The root line □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ has ten syllables in a nine-syllable verse and makes no sense as written ("the helpless one became victorious"); it is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "helplessly fell into a swoon." The commentary confirms this: it explains the word as utter dejection, then resumes "thus overwhelmed by the afflictions, remaining as though in a swoon (□□□□□□□)," and the next verse begins with regaining mindfulness. For the same reason the gloss □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ ("proud and intoxicated") is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "swooning and stupefied"; kept as written it would mean "as though proud and intoxicated."

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ ("external offering") cannot belong to the simile; it is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (or □□□□□), a weapon that cuts the body on the outside, set beside the barb lodged within. In order, the two images appear to match the latent afflictions (anuśaya) and the manifest entanglements (paryavasthāna). The exact wording is uncertain.

In the objection □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, □□□ is obscure; it is rendered from context as effort to hold the mind to its object, with □□□□ read as □□□□□ ("apply").

□□□□□ and □□□□□ are the Rāmāyaṇa and the Bhārata (Mahābhārata). □□□□□□□□ is taken as a garbled transliteration of Draupadī, whose abduction and recovery in the Bhārata parallels Sītā's in the Rāmāyaṇa; the identification is probable, not certain.

Minor slips read in their evident sense: □□□□□□□□□ as □□□□□□□□□, □□□□□□□ as □□□□□□, □□□□□ as □□□□□□, □□□□□ as □□□□□.

The glossary senses "tantra" for □□□□□, "empowerment" for □□□ and "self" for □□□ do not apply here: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is the mental continuum, □□□ is power or control (□□□□□□□□ "helpless"), and □□□ is the first-person pronoun.
• In □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

□□□□□ is the mental continuum or a stream; and □□□ is "power."
• □□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□, "the cause of the disease," matching □□□□□□ ("causes of disease") in the root verse.

□□□□□□ is rendered "right method" throughout this piece: the root line calls it the supreme elixir, set against medicine that turns to poison through faulty administration, and against unrefined metal on which the gold-making elixir has no effect. Its Sanskrit original is perhaps yukti, "proper application." The opening □□□□□ of the sentence introducing that verse is read as □□□□, "now."

"Quicksilver that appears as gold" translates a name, given with "called," for what seems to be an alchemical preparation of mercury. Its Sanskrit name has not been identified.

Minor slips read in their evident sense: □□□□□□□ as □□□□□□□□□□□, □□□□□□ as □□□□□.

In this piece □□□ is the ordinary word "time," not the name Kāla; □□□□□□ is loving-kindness, not Maitreya; □□□□ is the leper's extremities "fallen away"; □□□□□ is the mental continuum; and □□□ is "power."
• In the first sentence the text's nang sel is read as nad sel, "dispels the sickness," which the image of the elixir requires; later, mag ngag is read as man ngag, "instruction." The phrase rendered "the instruction reflected upon" (bsam pa'i man ngag) follows the commentator's own gloss: the teaching made certain through the wisdom born of hearing and reflection, which is then to be meditated on.
• The rare word rnab in "two ears" is read as rna ba, "ear".
The sentence explaining "whoever he is" is terse. It is taken to express the praiser's humility: lacking the Buddha's omniscience, he cannot name the exact mind and calm by which the Buddha works, and so he speaks of them indefinitely, not out of doubt.
• The commentator reads the moon in the root verse as a play on the name of the praise's author, Candragomin (candra, "moon"), and its whiteness as a sign of his purity. He also gives a second reading of Sukhāvatī, literally "possessing bliss," as the state endowed with the unsurpassed bliss of buddhahood.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.